

THE WARS OF PUNJAB

PART ELEVEN OF SIXTEEN

The Afghans and the Ghallugharas

Nine invasions in twenty years by a man who never lost a battle in the Punjab and never managed to keep it — and a community that lost perhaps half its people in one morning and took Lahore three years later.

1748 — 1767

WRITTEN AND RESEARCHED BY

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EVERY WAR FOUGHT ON THE SOIL OF PUNJAB

Told in plain words, from the very beginning

Nine Times Down the Same Road

Twenty years, three contenders and one province. At the end of it the Punjab is governed by people born in it, for the first time since 870.

This is the most violent twenty years in this book, and it is also the shortest span any part has covered.

Three powers wanted the Punjab. **Ahmad Shah Abdali** came down from Kabul nine times between 1748 and 1767, won every significant battle he fought here, sacked Delhi, destroyed the largest army India had put in the field for a century, and blew up the Harmandir Sahib twice. **The Marathas** came up from the Deccan, took Sirhind, took Lahore, and put a flag on the Indus at Attock — the furthest north any power from peninsular India had ever reached — and were annihilated within three years. **And the Dal Khalsa**, which had eleven divisions and no capital, lost perhaps half its fighting strength in a single morning in 1762 and held Lahore by 1765.

The winner is the one that could not be caught.

Four things to hold on to

- **Abdali is undefeated and irrelevant.** He wins at Lahore, at Delhi, at Panipat and at Kup, and by 1767 he goes home for the last time with nothing. **This part is a demonstration of the difference between winning battles and holding a country**, and there is no clearer case anywhere in these sixteen parts.
- **Panipat in 1761 is the largest battle fought in India in the eighteenth century** and it did not decide who ruled India. It decided who did not.
- **The two Ghallugharas define the period.** The lesser in 1746, in Part Ten; the greater on one February morning in 1762. What happens eight months after the second one is the most remarkable thing in this part.
- **And we have a hostile eyewitness.** A qazi riding with Abdali's army in 1764 wrote a campaign account that calls the Sikhs dogs on every page and describes their conduct in terms that read like praise. **After Part Ten's English merchants, this is the second genuinely valuable outside witness in this book.**

THE HONESTY LABELS, AND A WARNING ABOUT NUMBERS

CERTAIN means contemporary evidence — a participant, a document, a coin. **LIKELY** means well-attested and generally accepted. **STORY** means tradition.

The casualty figures in this part are the worst in the book and the least reliable. Panipat and the Vadda Ghallughara both produced numbers that vary by a factor of three between sources, and the reason is not carelessness — it is that both events killed large numbers of non-combatants in circumstances where nobody was counting. **Where this part gives a figure it gives a range and says whose it is.**

And one more thing, since this part contains two attacks on a place of worship. **The desecrations of the Harmandir Sahib in 1757 and 1762 are documented and are stated here plainly.** They were acts of policy, aimed at a building because the building was the centre of a community that could not be caught in the field.

Mir Mannu’s Punjab, 1748–1753

LIKELY

The governor who beat Abdali at Manupur spent five years hunting his own province, and the Punjabi couplet about him is the best thing anybody wrote in this century.

WON BY

Nobody — five years of a governor fighting on two fronts and losing both

WHEN 1748–1753, from Manupur to his death.	WHERE Lahore and the whole province.
WHO Muin-ul-Mulk — Mir Mannu — governor of Lahore, against the Dal Khalsa and against Abdali at the same time.	THE EVIDENCE Persian record, Sikh tradition, and one couplet that has outlived every document.

The impossible job

Mir Mannu was given Lahore in 1748 as the reward for winning at Manupur, and it was a poisoned gift. He had:

1. **An empire behind him that could not pay him.** Nadir Shah had taken the treasury nine years earlier. Delhi could give him a title and nothing else.
2. **Abdali in front of him.** The Afghan king came back in 1748–49 and again in 1751–52, and each time the answer was to concede more.
3. **And the Dal Khalsa inside the province,** newly organised as of March 1748 and expanding into every district the government could not garrison.

His response to the third problem was the policy of Part Ten, intensified. **Movable columns were sent through the districts with orders to kill; the bounty system was reinstated; families were seized at Lahore.** The Sikh sources for these years are among the grimmest in the tradition, and they concern women and children held in the city.

RAM RAUNI, 1748 — AND HOW A MISL GOT ITS NAME

The first serious action came almost immediately. In late 1748 a Sikh force was besieged in **Ram Rauni**, the new mud fort at Amritsar, by provincial troops under **Adina Beg Khan**, the faujdar of the Jalandhar Doab.

The siege lasted months and the position was close to hopeless. It was lifted through the intervention of **Diwan Kaura Mal**, Mir Mannu's Hindu Khatri revenue minister, who argued that the Sikhs were more useful as allies against a rival than as corpses — and who was known in Sikh sources by an affectionate nickname that turned his own name, which means bitter, into its opposite.

And during that siege, a commander in the government's own service named **Jassa Singh** changed sides and went into the fort. He afterwards rebuilt it and renamed it **Ramgarh**, and took his own name from it: **Jassa Singh Ramgarhia**, whose misl becomes one of the great powers of Part Twelve.

Two things in that paragraph are worth holding. A Hindu official saved the Sikhs at Amritsar in 1748; a Sikh officer of the Mughal government defected to them in the middle of a siege. **Part Ten said this book would name people rather than communities. Here is why.**

WHY MIR MANNU COULD NOT WIN

- **Two enemies, one army.** Every soldier used against the Sikhs was a soldier not on the Afghan frontier, and the reverse.
- **No money.** He was paying tribute to Kabul out of a province he could not fully tax.
- **The countryside was not his.** The *rakhi* system of Part Ten meant villages were already paying somebody else for protection, and getting it.
- **And there was nothing to besiege.** After Ram Rauni the Dal Khalsa went back to holding nothing.

WHAT HIS POLICY PRODUCED

- **Recruits.** The same mechanism as 1716 and 1746, and by now the state had run the experiment three times.
- **A hardened organisation.** Five years of pressure with a functioning assembly at Amritsar is five years of practice.
- **An exhausted province.** When Abdali came in 1752, Lahore could not hold him.
- **And his own death solved nothing.** He fell from his horse in November 1753 and the province fell apart faster without him.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Mannu Is Our Sickle

Of everything produced in the Punjab in the middle of the eighteenth century — the chronicles, the letters, the administrative records — the thing that has survived best is four lines of doggerel that nobody signed.

It is in Punjabi, it rhymes, and it says roughly this: **Mannu is our sickle and we are his crop; the more he cuts us down, the more we grow.**

It was said in villages, by people with a price on their heads, about the man who was hunting them, and it has been repeated for two hundred and seventy years.

Take it seriously as an argument, because it is one. **It is an accurate strategic assessment delivered as a joke.** A crop that is mowed grows back thicker; a policy of killing a community faster than it reproduces only works if you can actually find everybody, and Mir Mannu could not. He knew he could not. The couplet is telling him so.

And notice what it does not contain. There is no god in it, no revenge in it, no self-pity in it, and no threat. **It is contempt, expressed as agricultural observation, by farmers.**

This book has spent ten parts looking for the voice of the ordinary population of the Punjab and finding almost nothing — a coin legend in Part Three, a hymn in Part Seven, a letter to an emperor in Part Nine. Every one of those was produced by somebody exceptional.

This one is anonymous, it is funny, and it turned out to be right. Mir Mannu was dead within five years and the crop took Lahore twelve years after that.

Lahore, 1752 — The Province Is Signed Away

LIKELY

After a four-month siege, the Mughal emperor formally ceded the Punjab and Multan to the king of Afghanistan. On paper it settled everything. It settled nothing at all.

WON BY

Ahmad Shah Abdali — who acquired a province he could not administer

WHEN The siege through the winter of 1751–52; the cession in April 1752.	WHERE Lahore.
WHO Abdali's third invasion, against Mir Mannu.	THE EVIDENCE Mughal and Afghan records; the cession is a documented transfer.

What happened

1. **Abdali came back in late 1751** — his third crossing in four years — and invested Lahore.
2. **Mir Mannu held out for about four months.** The defence was real; this was not a city that opened its gates.
3. **Diwan Kaura Mal was killed** in the fighting outside the city — the man who had saved the Sikhs at Ram Rauni three years earlier, dying in the defence of Lahore against the Afghans.
4. **Mir Mannu was defeated and submitted.** And Abdali, in one of the shrewdest decisions in this part, **reappointed him as governor** — now holding Lahore for Kabul rather than for Delhi.
5. **In April 1752 the emperor in Delhi formally ceded the Punjab and Multan** to Ahmad Shah Abdali.

WHAT A CESSION IS WORTH

Look at what that document actually transferred.

Delhi gave away a province it did not control. The Mughal government had not been able to collect revenue across most of the Punjab for a decade, could not protect it, and had not sent an army into it since Manupur.

Kabul received a province it could not hold. Abdali's method was the campaign, not the garrison: he came, won, took what he could carry, appointed somebody, and went home before the hot weather. **An Afghan king ruling Lahore from Kandahar is exactly the arrangement the Ghaznavids had in Part Five and the Ghurids in Part Six, and it worked for them because they had no third party in the field.**

And the third party is the whole difference. **Between the departing empire and the arriving one there was, in 1752, an organised military confederacy of Punjabis with an assembly, a command structure and a protection-revenue system already running in the villages.**

Neither signatory to the cession mentioned them. Within thirteen years they had Lahore.

WHY ABDALI TOOK IT

- **He held the passes.** Part Five's rule, ninth appearance. Kandahar, Kabul and the Indus country had been his since 1747.
- **He could come back every year.** Three hundred miles from Peshawar to Lahore, in a good season, with cavalry.
- **Delhi could not respond.** No treasury, no field army, and a succession crisis of its own.
- **And he was patient about form.** Leaving Mir Mannu in place cost nothing and gave the transfer a legality it would otherwise have lacked.

WHY POSSESSION MEANT NOTHING

- **He never stayed.** Nine invasions and not one winter spent governing.
- **His governors were caught between two fires,** exactly as Mir Mannu had been — Afghan tribute above, Sikh *rakhi* below.
- **The revenue never arrived.** A province where villages pay somebody else for protection is not a taxable province.
- **And the more often he came, the more the Punjab organised against him.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Man Who Was Called Sweet

Diwan Kaura Mal was a Hindu Khatri from the Multan country who rose through the Mughal revenue service to become the diwan — the chief financial officer — of the Punjab under Mir Mannu.

He is remembered in Sikh tradition with an affection that is almost unique for a government official of that century, and the reason is a pun. His name, *Kaura*, means bitter. The Sikhs called him **Mitha Mal** — sweet.

What he did to earn it was practical rather than sentimental. In 1748 he argued Mir Mannu into lifting the siege of Ram Rauni. He consistently advocated accommodation rather than extermination. He is credited with securing the community's access to Amritsar at points when the policy was to deny it, and with using his position to moderate what the columns did in the districts.

He was not a sympathiser in any modern sense. **He was a senior official of the government doing the hunting, who thought the hunting was bad policy, and who had enough standing to say so.**

He was killed in 1752 outside Lahore, fighting the Afghans, in the service of the Mughal governor.

Set him beside **Lakhpatt Rai** from Part Ten — the other Hindu Khatri diwan of Lahore, who ran the worst massacre of the 1740s to avenge his brother. Same community, same office, same city, fifteen years apart, and opposite conduct.

That is what the eighteenth-century Punjab actually looked like from inside, and it is why this book keeps refusing to write sentences that begin with the name of a religion and end with a verb.

Delhi, Mathura and Amritsar, 1757

LIKELY

The fourth invasion took the capital of India, sacked two pilgrimage cities, and on the way home destroyed a building.

WON BY

Abdali — everywhere he went, and it changed nothing structurally

WHEN January to April 1757.	WHERE Delhi, Mathura and Vrindavan, and then Amritsar on the return.
WHO Abdali's fourth invasion; the Amritsar operation under his general Jahan Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Persian and Afghan accounts, Maratha correspondence, and Sikh tradition.

What happened

1. **He entered Delhi in January 1757** and held it for about a month. The city was systematically stripped — the second such stripping in eighteen years, and there was much less left to take than Nadir Shah had found.
2. **Then Mathura and Vrindavan.** The sack of these two Hindu pilgrimage cities in the spring of 1757 was accompanied by a massacre that the sources on all sides describe in similar terms.
3. **An epidemic — described as cholera — broke out in his army** and forced the withdrawal earlier than planned.
4. **On the way home he dealt with Amritsar.** In April 1757, Jahan Khan's troops **demolished the Harmandir Sahib and filled the sacred tank with debris and the carcasses of slaughtered animals.**
5. **He left his son Timur Shah as viceroy at Lahore** with Jahan Khan to run the province.

WHY THE BUILDING

It is worth being precise about the military logic here, because it is not mysterious and it is not incidental.

The Dal Khalsa could not be brought to battle. Ten parts of this book have established what that means: no capital, no field army to destroy, nothing to besiege, a population that will not inform. Abdali had the finest cavalry in Asia and there was nothing to point it at.

But the community had one fixed point, and everybody knew where it was. The assembly met at Amritsar twice a year. The Harmandir Sahib was the one address the Khalsa could not abandon.

So the building was attacked, twice — in 1757 and again in 1762 — as the only available substitute for an enemy that would not stand still. **It is the same reasoning that produced the destruction of Sirhind in 1710, in the opposite direction: when you cannot reach the people, you go for the place.**

It did not work either time, and the reason is the subject of War Ten. **The community rebuilt the tank and came back to it within months on both occasions,** and the second desecration produced the largest assembly at Amritsar in twenty years.

WHY NOTHING COULD STOP HIM

- **Nobody in northern India had a field army.** Delhi had no treasury; the Punjab's governor was his own appointee; the Marathas were not yet in position.
- **Speed.** He crossed the Indus in the cold weather and was back before the heat every single time.
- **He came for plunder, not for territory.** An objective you can carry away is an objective you always achieve.
- **And he had allies in the doab.** The Rohilla Afghans of the Ganges country welcomed him and would be decisive at Panipat four years later.

WHAT HE COULD NOT ACHIEVE

- **A settled province.** Timur Shah lasted just over a year at Lahore before being thrown out by the Marathas.
- **An end to the Dal Khalsa.** Which is why he came back five more times.
- **Any revenue worth the name.** Plunder is one-off; taxation requires a government.
- **And the destruction at Amritsar bought him an enemy that would never negotiate.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Tank That Kept Being Refilled

The pool at Amritsar was dug in the 1570s by Guru Ram Das, and the town took its name from it — *Amritsar*, the pool of nectar. Part Eight described its founding. The shrine in the middle of it was completed under Guru Arjan by about 1589.

In this part it is destroyed twice — in 1757 and again in 1762 — and on both occasions the tank itself was deliberately fouled: filled with rubble and with the carcasses of cattle, which in that context is not vandalism but a message, and everybody involved understood it as one.

Both times it was cleared and refilled.

That is the whole of it, and it is worth pausing on because it is the most literal illustration in this book of the difference between a place and an institution.

You can demolish a building in a day. What you cannot demolish is the fact that several thousand armed men, scattered across a province, have agreed to be in the same field twice a year on two fixed dates. The dates are in a calendar; the calendar is in a book; the book is in every congregation in the Punjab. **The tank is where they meet, not why.**

Part Nine described a Guru taking initiation from five men he had just created so that the order would outlive him. Part Ten described a movement that survived thirty years by owning nothing that could be taken. **Here is the same principle again, and the enemy testing it directly with gunpowder.**

The Harmandir Sahib standing today is a later building. The tank is the same water in the same place, and it has been cleared out and refilled more than once by people who were being hunted at the time.

Gohalwar, November 1757 — The Old Man

LIKELY

A seventy-five-year-old scholar left his desk, raised a force, and died within sight of the town.

WON BY

The Afghan garrison — and the man who lost is the one everybody remembers

WHEN

November 1757, about seven months after the demolition.

WHERE

Gohalwar, a few miles from Amritsar.

WHO

Baba Deep Singh and a volunteer force, against the Afghan troops holding Amritsar.

THE EVIDENCE

Sikh tradition. The core is accepted; the most famous element is not history.

What happened

1. **Baba Deep Singh was a scholar** — one of the leading figures in the copying and transmission of the scripture, based at Damdama Sahib in the Malwa, and by 1757 he was about seventy-five.
2. **News of the demolition reached him** and he undertook to go and reclaim the site.
3. **A force gathered as he moved north.** The tradition describes numbers accumulating from village to village on the road to Amritsar.
4. **They were intercepted at Gohalwar**, a few miles short, by the Afghan troops from the city.
5. **The fighting was severe and Baba Deep Singh was killed.** The Sikh force did not take Amritsar.

THE FAMOUS PART, AND WHAT TO DO WITH IT

The image everybody knows — **the old man fighting on after being mortally struck, carrying his own severed head in one hand and his weapon in the other, until he reaches the edge of the sacred tank** — is **STORY**. It is one of the most reproduced images in Sikh devotional art and it is not something that happened.

This book has said the same about the elephant at Hastivanj in Part Four, about Prithviraj's arrow in Part Six, and about the fifty-two rajas' cloak in Part Nine. **The rule does not bend for anybody.**

But look at what the historical core actually is, because it does not need decorating. **A man of seventy-five, whose life had been spent copying and teaching a text, put it down, raised a force out of the villages, marched on a garrisoned town, and was killed a few miles short of it.**

He knew the odds. Everybody who went with him knew the odds. They went anyway, seven months after the thing they were going to reclaim had been blown up, at a moment when the community was officially supposed to have been suppressed for the fourth time in fifty years.

The legend exists because the fact needed a shape. A story about a man who would not stop is what you get when a community tries to explain to itself why an old scholar walked to Amritsar.

WHY THE ATTEMPT FAILED

- **A volunteer force against regular troops.** Men gathered on the road, without artillery, against an Afghan garrison in position.
- **They were intercepted short of the objective,** in the open, which is the one place the Dal Khalsa never chose to fight.
- **It was not a Dal Khalsa operation.** This was a march undertaken on its own account, not a campaign agreed by the assembly.

WHY IT MATTERED ANYWAY

- **It answered the demolition within the year.** Which is what the demolition had been designed to make impossible.
- **It came out of the Malwa.** The community south of the Sutlej mobilising for Amritsar showed the assembly was still binding people three hundred kilometres apart.
- **And it gave the century one of its two or three central images.** Which, for a movement that survives on what its people are willing to do, is not a small military asset.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Scribe

The thing usually left out of the story of Baba Deep Singh is what he did for the fifty years before it.

He was a scribe. He worked on copies of the scripture — the painstaking, unglamorous business of reproducing a large text by hand, accurately, so that congregations across the Punjab could have one. He was associated with the establishment at **Damdama Sahib**, in the Malwa country, which is where the definitive recension of the Guru Granth Sahib is traditionally held to have been prepared under Guru Gobind Singh, and he is remembered as having been part of that work.

In a community being hunted with a price on every head, in a province where owning the book could be fatal, **somebody had to keep making copies.**

Ten parts of this history have been about the loss of records. Taxila's libraries burned in Part Four. Anandpur's manuscripts went into the Sarsa in the dark in Part Nine. **The single greatest complaint of this entire book is that the Punjab's own account of itself keeps not surviving.**

It survives from the eighteenth century, through the worst persecution in the province's history, because men like this one sat and copied it out while the columns were in the districts.

And then, at seventy-five, he put the pen down and went to Amritsar.

The warrior is what the paintings show. The scribe is why there is anything to paint.

Attock, 1758 — The Marathas Reach the Indus LIKELY

An army from the Deccan took Sirhind, took Lahore, drove the Afghan viceroy out of the Punjab, and planted a flag on the Indus. It is the furthest north a power from peninsular India had ever come, and it lasted four months.

WON BY

The Marathas — and it is the high point and the beginning of the end

WHEN March to May 1758.	WHERE Sirhind, then Lahore, then Attock on the Indus.
WHO Raghunath Rao and Malharrao Holkar, with Adina Beg Khan and Sikh contingents, against Timur Shah and Jahan Khan.	THE EVIDENCE Maratha correspondence, which is abundant and excellent; Persian accounts; Sikh tradition.

How the Marathas got there

They had been expanding north for a generation. From a base in the Deccan they had made themselves the effective power behind the Mughal throne — protecting Delhi, collecting tribute across northern India, and by the 1750s holding a claim to defend the empire that the empire itself could not enforce.

In 1757, after Abdali sacked Delhi and Mathura and went home leaving his son at Lahore, the Marathas were invited north to deal with it — and **Adina Beg Khan**, the endlessly resourceful faujdar of the Jalandhar Doab, brokered it. He had spent his career playing Mughals, Afghans, Marathas and Sikhs against each other, and this was his masterpiece.

What happened

1. **Sirhind fell in March 1758** to a combined force of Marathas, Adina Beg’s troops and Sikhs.
2. **Lahore fell in April.** Timur Shah and Jahan Khan were driven out of the Punjab entirely.
3. **The pursuit went to the Indus.** Maratha detachments took **Attock** in May 1758 and raided towards Peshawar.

4. **Adina Beg was installed as governor** on a very large annual tribute to Pune — and died in September, five months later.
5. **And the alliance came apart.** Maratha troops in the Punjab behaved as armies of occupation do; the Sikhs, who had helped take both Sirhind and Lahore, got nothing they regarded as their share; and the relationship curdled.
6. **The Maratha hold lasted until Abdali came back at the end of 1759.**

WHY THE SIKHS SAT OUT PANIPAT

This is one of the most argued-over questions in eighteenth-century Indian history and the answer is mostly in 1758.

The Sikhs had been useful allies and were treated as auxiliaries. They provided troops and local knowledge for the campaigns that took Sirhind and Lahore, and the settlement afterwards gave the province to Adina Beg and the revenue to Pune.

The Marathas were an occupying army, not a liberating one. Their method across northern India was *chauth* — a demand for a quarter of the revenue, enforced by cavalry. To a Punjabi village it was not obviously different from what Lahore had been doing.

And the Maratha commanders did not think they needed them. The army that marched to Panipat was the largest and best-equipped force in India and its leadership was confident.

So when the decisive campaign came in 1760, the Dal Khalsa was not in it. **What they did instead was watch the Afghans go past, and then attack them on the way home** — which is War Seven, and which is the strategy of a power that has learned exactly what it is good at.

Whether a Sikh alliance would have changed Panipat is unanswerable and endlessly asserted. What can be said is narrower: **the two forces that could have fought Abdali together in 1761 had fallen out in 1758 over the division of the Punjab.**

WHY THE MARATHAS GOT TO ATTOCK

- **Abdali had gone home.** They fought Timur Shah, not his father, and the difference was decisive.
- **They had local partners.** Adina Beg's intelligence and the Sikh contingents made the campaign possible.
- **Excellent light cavalry.** The Maratha army moved fast and lived off the country as well as anybody in Asia.
- **And nobody defended the Punjab for Kabul.** The province had no reason to.

WHY THEY COULD NOT HOLD IT

- **Two thousand kilometres from Pune.** The oldest problem in this book, and the Marathas had no Grand Trunk Road equivalent running south.
- **They governed by extraction.** *Chauth* is a revenue demand, not an administration, and it makes no friends.
- **Adina Beg died.** The one man who could actually run the province lasted five months.
- **And they had alienated the only local force that mattered,** which cost them nothing in 1758 and everything in 1761.

The Flag on the Indus

In May 1758, Maratha troops stood on the bank of the Indus at Attock — the crossing where Timur bridged the river in 1398 and where Akbar built the fort in the 1580s.

They had come from Pune. It is roughly two thousand kilometres in a straight line and considerably more by road.

No power based in peninsular India had ever reached that point. Not the Satavahanas, not the Chalukyas, not Vijayanagara, not the Bahmanis. The Mauryas and the Guptas and the Mughals had all held the Indus, but they were northern powers reaching west. **This was the Deccan reaching the Afghan frontier, and it had never happened before and has not happened since.**

It lasted about eighteen months in the Punjab as a whole and four months at Attock.

Two and a half years later, on 14 January 1761, the army that had done it was destroyed sixty miles from Delhi and the Maratha empire never recovered its ambitions in the north.

There is a lesson here that this book has been repeating since Part Three and that gets forgotten every time. **The furthest extent of an empire is almost always the moment before its collapse, and for exactly the same reason: the reach that produced it is the overreach that ends it.**

Chandragupta II's inscription boasts of crossing the seven mouths of the Sindhu. Muhammad bin Tughluq's empire reached its greatest extent about four years before it dissolved. The Maratha flag at Attock in May 1758 is the same phenomenon, dated to the month.

Panipat, 14 January 1761

CERTAIN

The largest battle fought in India in a century, on the same ground as 1526 and 1556 — and it decided who would not rule India rather than who would.

WON BY Ahmad Shah Abdali — who went home and never governed a square mile of it

WHEN 14 January 1761, from morning to mid-afternoon.	WHERE Panipat, on the Grand Trunk Road north of Delhi — the third decisive battle on that field in 235 years.
WHO Sadashivrao Bhau for the Marathas, against Abdali and his Indian allies.	THE NUMBERS Perhaps 45,000–60,000 Maratha fighting troops, with a camp of civilians several times that. Abdali’s coalition of similar fighting strength, with better cavalry and artillery.

How they came to be there

1. **Abdali came back at the end of 1759** to recover what the Marathas had taken, and made alliances the Marathas could not match — the Rohilla Afghans of the Ganges doab under **Najib-ud-Daula**, and the Nawab of Awadh, **Shuja-ud-Daula**.
2. **The Marathas sent a great army north** under Sadashivrao Bhau, with the Peshwa’s son Vishwasrao, and with **Ibrahim Khan Gardi** commanding European-trained infantry and artillery.
3. **They took Delhi in August 1760**, and then Kunjpura in October — where the Afghan garrison was massacred, which hardened everything that followed.
4. **Then Abdali crossed the Yamuna behind them** and cut them off from Delhi and from the south.
5. **And the two armies sat facing each other for about two months.** This is the part that decided it. **The Maratha camp contained tens of thousands of non-combatants — pilgrims, families, camp followers — and it slowly starved.**
6. **On 14 January the Marathas attacked**, because they had to.

What happened on the day

1. **The Maratha centre and left did well in the morning.** Ibrahim Khan Gardi's infantry and guns pushed the Afghan right back, and Bhau's centre broke into the enemy line.
2. **Abdali held his reserve.** Several thousand of his best troops were kept out of the fighting for hours, and he committed them in the afternoon — **the same answer Muhammad of Ghor used at Tarain in Part Six and Babur used at Panipat in Part Seven.**
3. **Vishwasrao was killed** — shot, in the middle of the fighting, in full view of the army.
4. **Bhau went in after him and disappeared.** His body was identified afterwards.
5. **And the army broke.** Not gradually. The accounts describe a line that was holding and then, within a short time of the two men going down, was not there.
6. **The pursuit and the aftermath were worse than the battle.** Tens of thousands were killed in the rout; a very large number of prisoners were killed the following day; and the civilians in the camp were caught in all of it.

THE SINGLE POINT OF FAILURE, FOR THE SEVENTH TIME

This book has been counting, and Panipat is the clearest case yet.

Porus's elephants in Part Two. Anandapala's elephant at Waihind in Part Five. Muhammad of Ghor wounded at Tarain in Part Six. Qutlugh Khwaja hit at Kili. Hemu's arrow at Panipat in Part Eight. Wazir Khan killed at Chappar Chiri in Part Ten. And now Vishwasrao shot and Bhau gone, and one of the finest armies in Asia disintegrating within an hour of it.

The mechanism never varies. **An army held together by the visible presence of its commanders, with no institutional structure that can fight the battle without them.**

And it is worth noting who does not suffer from it. Abdali kept a reserve and directed the battle from outside it. His army was a professional force under a single owner with subordinate commanders who could act.

So was the Dal Khalsa, which was not on that field — eleven misls, each under its own leader, any of whom could be killed without the others stopping. That is not a coincidence and it is the reason the last war of this part goes the way it does.

WHY ABDALI WON

- **He cut them off and waited.** Two months of blockade did more than the battle. **Blockades always work; Part Ten made the point at Gurdas Nangal and here it is at national scale.**
- **He had allies and they had none.** The Rohillas and Awadh gave him numbers, supplies and local knowledge in a country the Marathas were operating in as strangers.
- **Better cavalry and mounted firepower.** Afghan horse and camel-mounted swivel guns against an army built around infantry and heavy artillery.
- **And he held a reserve until the afternoon.** The oldest winning move in this book.

WHY THE MARATHAS LOST

- **They fought at the end of a two-thousand-kilometre line** with no secure supply and no friendly province behind them.
- **They brought a civilian camp to a war.** Tens of thousands of non-combatants meant they could not manoeuvre, could not disperse, and starved faster.
- **They had made enemies of everyone in the north.** Rohillas, Awadh, Rajputs and Sikhs all had reasons to prefer them beaten.
- **And they attacked because they were starving,** which is the worst reason to attack anybody.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Two Pearls Dissolved

The news had to be sent to Pune, two thousand kilometres away, and the letter that carried it is one of the most famous sentences in Indian history.

It reports the disaster in code, in the language of a jeweller taking stock. **Two pearls have been dissolved. Twenty-seven gold coins have been lost. And of the silver and the copper, the total cannot be cast up.**

The two pearls were Vishwasrao, the Peshwa's son and heir, and Sadashivrao Bhau, his cousin and the commander. The gold coins were the senior commanders. The silver and copper were everybody else.

Of the silver and the copper, the total cannot be cast up.

Modern estimates of the dead run from forty thousand upward for the battle itself, with a comparable number of prisoners killed afterwards and an unknown but very large number of the civilians who had come north with the army. **Almost every substantial family in Maharashtra lost somebody at Panipat**, and the phrase is still used in Marathi to mean a catastrophe.

The Peshwa, Balaji Baji Rao, received the news and died in June, five months later.

And here is the part that makes it a Punjab story rather than a Maratha one. **Abdali had just destroyed the largest army in India and had northern India lying open in front of him. He did not take it.** His own troops were owed pay and wanted to go home; his supply position was bad; and he had no administration capable of governing anything east of the Indus.

So he went back up the Grand Trunk Road, through the Punjab, with his columns strung out and loaded — **and that is War Seven.**

The Road Home, 1761

LIKELY

The Sikhs did not fight at Panipat. They fought the winner on his way back, took what he was carrying, and then walked into Lahore.

WON BY

The Dal Khalsa — by attacking the one thing Abdali could not defend

WHEN

February–March 1761 on the road;
November 1761 at Lahore.

WHERE

The Grand Trunk Road through the Punjab, and
then **Lahore**.

WHO

The misls under **Jassa Singh Ahluwalia**,
against Abdali's returning columns.

THE EVIDENCE

Sikh tradition and Persian accounts, which
agree on the raiding if not on the numbers.

What happened

1. **Abdali withdrew north in February 1761**, with the plunder of a campaign and a very large number of prisoners taken at and after Panipat — mostly women and children being carried to Afghanistan.
2. **The misls attacked the columns repeatedly**. Not a battle: a series of raids on the flanks and the rear of a strung-out army moving through country the raiders knew and the army did not.
3. **Prisoners were taken off the columns and freed**. The tradition records this in detail and gives figures in the low thousands; Persian sources acknowledge the losses without the arithmetic. **The freed captives were escorted back to their homes across northern India**.
4. **Abdali got home**, having lost baggage and prisoners and gained nothing he could keep.
5. **And in November 1761 the Dal Khalsa took Lahore**. The Afghan governor could not hold it. **Jassa Singh Ahluwalia was proclaimed Sultan-ul-Qaum — king of the nation — and a coin was struck**.
6. **They did not try to hold it**. When Abdali came back in strength at the end of the year, they left the city and dispersed, which is the method that had kept them alive for forty years.

HANDLE WITH CARE

The rescue of the Panipat captives is one of the best-known episodes in Sikh tradition, and the numbers given for it vary. The figure most often quoted is in the region of two thousand two hundred; other accounts give more.

What is solid: Abdali's return march through the Punjab in early 1761 was harassed continuously; his columns lost baggage and prisoners; and captives taken at Panipat were freed by Sikh bands and sent home. Persian sources hostile to the Sikhs record the harassment and the losses without disputing what caused them.

What is not solid: any specific total.

And the second event needs its own caution. **Whether a coin was actually struck at Lahore in November 1761, or whether the striking belongs to the occupation of 1765, is disputed among numismatists.** The proclamation of Jassa Singh Ahluwalia as *Sultan-ul-Qaum* is well attested; the metal is argued about.

WHY THE RAIDING WORKED

- **A loaded army cannot manoeuvre.** Part Six made this exact point about the Mongols at Jaran-Manjur in 1298 — plunder is heavy and nobody will abandon it.
- **They chose the moment.** Not before Panipat, not during it, but on the return, when the winner was tired, strung out and going away.
- **They knew the ground.** Four hundred kilometres of road through their own country.
- **And they were not trying to beat him.** The objective was the baggage and the captives, and both were achievable.

WHY THEY GAVE LAHORE UP AGAIN

- **They could not hold a city against Abdali in the field.** They had known this since 1748 and it did not change until 1765.
- **A garrison is a target.** The lesson of Banda at Lohgarh and Gurdas Nangal, learned permanently.
- **The misls were a raiding confederacy, not yet a state.** Holding a capital requires an administration nobody had built.
- **And Abdali was coming.** Within three months he was back, and War Eight is what happened.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

What They Did With the Winner

Stand back from January and February of 1761 and look at the whole shape of it, because it is the clearest strategic lesson in this part.

The Marathas fought Abdali properly. They brought the largest and best-equipped army in India, with European-trained infantry and a modern artillery train, met him on a chosen field, and were destroyed in an afternoon along with tens of thousands of their people.

The Sikhs did not fight him at all. They watched him go past, let him win, and then attacked his baggage on the road home.

Nine months later the Marathas were finished as a power in northern India, and the Dal Khalsa was in Lahore proclaiming a king.

It is worth being honest about how this looks. **There is no glory in it.** Nobody has painted the raids on the Grand Trunk Road in February 1761. The battle honours belong to Panipat, and Panipat was a catastrophe.

But look at what forty-five years of being hunted had taught. **Never fight the enemy's battle. Never hold what he can take. Attack what he cannot defend, when he is going away. Have no capital to lose and no army that dies with a commander.**

Part Ten described where that method came from — the Lakhi Jungle, the bounty years, Gurdas Nangal. This is what it was for.

And the thing it produced on that road was not only plunder. **Several thousand people who had been taken north as slaves were pulled off those columns and walked home,** to places all over northern India, by a confederacy that was itself under a standing order of extermination.

Of everything in this part, that is the paragraph to keep.

The Vadda Ghallughara, 5 February 1762

LIKELY

He marched two hundred kilometres in about two days and caught them with their families on the road. It is the worst morning in Sikh history.

WON BY Ahmad Shah Abdali — the greatest single loss the community has ever taken

WHEN	WHERE
5 February 1762, in one day.	Near Kup and Rahira, close to Malerkotla, in the Malwa country south of the Sutlej.
WHO	THE NUMBERS
Abdali's sixth invasion, with the Sirhind and Malerkotla forces, against the whole Dal Khalsa and its <i>vahir</i> .	Killed: sources give between about ten thousand and thirty thousand . Sikh tradition puts it near the upper figure.

What made it possible

Everything the community had done for forty-five years depended on one thing: **being able to disperse**. Bands on horseback, nothing to defend, no fixed position, no baggage.

In February 1762 they were not dispersed and they were not unencumbered. **They were moving the *vahir*** — the whole non-combatant body of the community, women, children, the old and the sick, with their possessions — south-west across the Malwa towards the safety of the desert country, because Abdali had come back into the Punjab and the villages were no longer safe.

An army escorting its own families cannot scatter. That is the entire explanation of what followed.

What happened

1. **Abdali force-marched from Lahore**. The accounts describe a distance of roughly two hundred kilometres covered in something close to forty-eight hours. It is a remarkable feat of movement and it is why the Sikhs were caught at all.
2. **He was joined by the Afghan forces of Sirhind and Malerkotla**, so the trap closed from more than one direction.

3. **The Dal Khalsa did the only thing available.** The fighting men formed a moving ring around the *vahir* and tried to keep marching south-west while fighting on all sides.
4. **The running battle went on for most of the day** over many kilometres of open country towards Barnala.
5. **The ring held and the losses were catastrophic.** Most of the dead were non-combatants. **Jassa Singh Ahluwalia was carried off the field with wounds counted in the dozens.**
6. **A remnant reached the desert country and survived.**

ON THE NUMBER, AND ON WHAT “HALF” MEANS

The figures for the Vadda Ghallughara are the least reliable in this book, and the reason should be stated. **Most of the dead were civilians on a road, killed over many hours across a wide stretch of country, and nobody counted them.**

Sikh tradition gives figures around twenty-five to thirty thousand and holds that this was somewhere near half the community. Persian sources give lower numbers, as sources do when the killing includes non-combatants. Modern historians generally accept something in the range of ten to thirty thousand and decline to be more precise.

What is not in doubt is the character of it. This was not a defeat in the field. It was the destruction of a population that its own army was trying to shield while walking.

And the name records the judgement. Part Ten explained why 1746 is called the *Chhota* — lesser — Ghallughara. **It is called lesser because of this one.**

WHY ABDALI SUCCEEDED

- **Speed.** The march from Lahore is the whole battle. He arrived before anybody thought he could.
- **He caught them encumbered.** The one condition under which the Dal Khalsa could not use its only real advantage.
- **Open ground.** The Malwa plain in February — no forest, no marsh, no hills, nothing to break up cavalry.
- **And he had local allies closing the other side.**

WHY THEY COULD NOT AVOID IT

- **They would not abandon the *vahir*.** The fighting men could have dispersed and lived. They did not, and that decision is the reason for the casualty figure.
- **They were between refuges.** Caught in the open between the villages they had left and the desert they were making for.
- **They had no warning.** The march from Lahore outran the intelligence network that had protected them for forty years.
- **And there was nowhere to stand.** No fort, no hills, no river — only a ring of men walking.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Malerkotla

The battle was fought a few miles from the small state of **Malerkotla**, whose Afghan ruling family sent troops to join Abdali on that February morning.

And Malerkotla is the one place in the Punjab that Sikh armies afterwards did not touch.

The reason goes back to Part Nine, to Sirhind in December 1704. When the two younger sons of Guru Gobind Singh were brought before Wazir Khan and sentence was passed, the tradition records that **the Nawab of Malerkotla, Sher Muhammad Khan, spoke against it** — objecting that whatever quarrel there was with the father, it could not be visited on children. The protest is remembered as the *haah da naara*, the cry of protest, and it did not save them.

It saved Malerkotla. In the decades when Sikh power was sweeping the Malwa and every Afghan-held town in the plains was being taken and in several cases destroyed — Sirhind twice — **Malerkotla was spared, and the reason given was always the same one.**

It survived as a princely state into the twentieth century. And in 1947, when the Punjab was being partitioned and the killing on both sides of the new border was as bad as anything in this book, **Malerkotla is recorded as having come through it without the massacres that consumed the districts around it.** The explanation offered locally, then and since, was a protest made in a courtroom in 1704.

How much weight that single act can really bear across two hundred and forty years is a fair question and this book will not pretend to settle it.

What is certain is that a community which lost perhaps half its people a few miles from that town, partly to troops sent from it, chose to remember instead a Muslim nobleman who had objected to the killing of two children — and acted on that memory for two centuries.

Amritsar, April 1762 — The Second Demolition

LIKELY

Two months after Kup he went back to the tank and did it again, and this time something came off the building and hit him.

WON BY

Abdali — for about six months

WHEN April 1762.	WHERE Amritsar.
WHO Abdali, in person this time, rather than through a general.	THE EVIDENCE Afghan, Persian and Sikh accounts, which agree.

What happened

1. **He came to Amritsar after Kup**, while the community was scattered and its army was in the desert country recovering.
2. **The Harmandir Sahib — rebuilt after 1757 — was blown up with gunpowder.**
3. **The tank was filled again** with rubble and the carcasses of slaughtered cattle.
4. **And, according to widely repeated accounts, a fragment of the building struck him in the face**, leaving a wound on the nose that never healed properly.
5. **Then he went back to Lahore**, and shortly afterwards home.

THE WOUND

The story that a piece of the demolished building hit Ahmad Shah Abdali in the face, and that the resulting wound became the illness that eventually killed him, is repeated in a great many accounts and deserves careful handling.

What is documented: Abdali suffered for years from a disease of the face and nose — the sources describe an ulcerating growth — which got progressively worse, was treated unsuccessfully, disfigured him, and contributed to his death in 1772.

What is tradition: that it began with a flying fragment at Amritsar in April 1762.

Medical opinion, to the extent anybody can offer one at this distance, generally reads the illness as a tumour rather than an infected wound. **The connection to Amritsar is** STORY, **and it is a story with an obvious appeal to the people telling it.**

But there is a reason it is worth including even when labelled. **The man who twice destroyed the Harmandir Sahib spent the last decade of his life with a disfiguring illness that made it hard for him to eat, and died of it at about fifty.** The tradition did not have to invent the ending, only the cause.

WHY HE DID IT AGAIN

- **It was the only fixed target he had.** Same reasoning as 1757, unchanged.
- **The moment was as good as it would get.** Two months after Kup, with the Dal Khalsa broken and dispersed.
- **And he had nothing else to show.** He had won at Panipat and at Kup and held nothing; the demolition was a result he could point to.

WHY IT WAS THE WORSE MISTAKE

- **It gave a shattered community a fixed date to reassemble on.** Which is exactly what happened in October.
- **It removed any possibility of a settlement.** Abdali made peace overtures within the year and they went nowhere, and this is why.
- **It confirmed that he could not find the enemy.** Blowing up a building is what you do when you cannot reach an army.
- **And they rebuilt it. Again.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

Six Months

Count the interval, because it is the single most extraordinary fact in this part and it is easy to read past.

5 February 1762: the Dal Khalsa is caught in the open with its families and loses something between ten and thirty thousand people in a day. Its commander-in-chief is carried off the field with wounds beyond counting. The survivors are in the desert.

April 1762: their central shrine is blown up and their sacred tank filled with carcasses, for the second time in five years.

17 October 1762: they are back at Amritsar in force, for the Diwali assembly, and they fight Ahmad Shah Abdali to a standstill on that ground.

Eight months from the worst day in their history to standing on the same field as the man who caused it.

This book has described a great many recoveries and none of them are like this. **The Shahis took sixty years to lose in Part Five and never came back. The Marathas lost once at Panipat and never returned to the north. The Lodis, the Suris, Hemu, Banda — every defeat of this magnitude in these eleven parts ended something.**

The mechanism is the one Part Nine built and Part Ten tested. **There was no leader whose death would end it, no capital whose loss would end it, and no army whose destruction would end it** — only an assembly with two fixed dates in a calendar that every congregation in the Punjab possessed a copy of.

Abdali could kill people, and did, on a scale this book has rarely had to describe. **He could not make Diwali not happen.**

Amritsar, October 1762 — Diwali

LIKELY

They came back for the festival, he came out of Lahore to stop them, and at the end of the day neither side had moved. That was the turning point.

WON BY

Nobody — and a drawn battle was worth more to the Sikhs than a victory

WHEN 17 October 1762.	WHERE Amritsar.
WHO The reassembled Dal Khalsa against Abdali, who marched from Lahore to prevent the gathering.	THE EVIDENCE Afghan and Sikh accounts, which agree that it was indecisive and disagree about everything else.

What happened

1. **The Sarbat Khalsa was called for Diwali** at Amritsar, as it had been every year that it was possible and several when it was not.
2. **They came.** From the Malwa, from the Doab, from the Majha — the misls converged on a town whose shrine had been rubble since April.
3. **Abdali marched from Lahore to break it up.** Roughly sixty kilometres, at speed, in the expectation of catching them assembled and unready as at Kup.
4. **This time they were not encumbered and they were ready.** The fighting lasted through the day.
5. **Neither side broke.** At nightfall Abdali withdrew towards Lahore, and the Sikhs held the ground.
6. **Within a short time he was making peace overtures** — offering terms, recognition, arrangements. They were not taken up.
7. **And in December he went home.**

WHY A DRAW WAS A VICTORY

Nothing was captured on 17 October and no army was destroyed. Here is why it is the hinge of the whole part.

Abdali's entire method depended on being able to catch them. Nine invasions in fourteen years had produced exactly one decisive engagement against the Sikhs — Kup — and that had required a forced march of two hundred kilometres and the accident of finding them escorting their families.

At Amritsar in October he knew exactly where they were, they were assembled in one place, they had been shattered eight months earlier, and he marched sixty kilometres to hit them. **And he could not do it.**

Everybody in the Punjab drew the conclusion at once. The peace overtures that followed were the strongest possible admission: **the king of Afghanistan, undefeated in India for fifteen years, offering terms to a confederacy with no capital eight months after nearly destroying it.**

Part Five made the point about Kashmir and Lohkot, which Mahmud attacked twice and failed twice. **The invader who cannot finish the job has already lost; he simply does not know it for a few more years.**

WHY THE SIKHS HELD

- **They were fighting unencumbered.** No *vahir*, no baggage, on ground of their own choosing, for the first time in that campaign.
- **Everybody was there.** The Diwali assembly concentrated the whole confederacy in one place — the one occasion each year when the misls fought as a single army.
- **Their command could take losses.** Eleven leaders, no single point of failure, and the man who had been carried off at Kup back in the field.
- **And they had nowhere else to be.** The site had already been destroyed twice; there was no version of retreating that meant anything.

WHY ABDALI COULD NOT FINISH IT

- **He had spent his one advantage.** Surprise had worked in February and could not work again.
- **His army wanted to go home.** Fifteen years of campaigning in India with pay in arrears and diminishing returns.
- **He had no base in the province.** Lahore was a garrison, not a government, and the countryside fed the other side.
- **And there was nothing left to destroy.** He had already blown up the only fixed thing they had, twice.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Calendar as a Weapon

Consider what the Sarbat Khalsa actually was, as a piece of military technology, because that is the right way to look at it.

It was two dates. **Vaisakhi in the spring and Diwali in the autumn, at Amritsar.** On those days, whoever could come, came, and what was decided bound everybody.

That is all. There was no permanent headquarters, no standing council, no records office, no capital and nothing to garrison. **The entire command apparatus of the Dal Khalsa consisted of an agreement about when to be in the same field.**

Now look at what it did between 1748 and 1765. It appointed a commander-in-chief. It divided the province among eleven misls and made the division stick. It allocated campaigns. It set the *rakhi* arrangements. It decided whether to accept an Afghan king's offer of terms — and decided not to.

And it could not be attacked. Abdali could burn Amritsar, and did, and the assembly met at Amritsar anyway, because the assembly was not the buildings.

Set this beside every other command system in these eleven parts. **Alexander's, which was Alexander. Prithviraj's coalition, which had no mechanism to decide anything. The Maratha army at Panipat, which dissolved when two men went down. Abdali's own, which was a king and his household troops and which ceased to exist when he died in 1772.**

The most durable political institution in this book is two dates and a rule about who has to obey the outcome — and it was built by people who could not afford a building.

Sirhind, January 1764

LIKELY

The town came down a second time, and this time it did not change hands again.

WON BY

The Dal Khalsa — and the Punjab east of the Sutlej became theirs

WHEN 14 January 1764.	WHERE Sirhind, on the Grand Trunk Road.
WHO The misls under Jassa Singh Ahluwalia, Charat Singh Sukerchakia, Hari Singh Bhangi and others, against Zain Khan, the Afghan governor.	THE EVIDENCE Sikh and Persian accounts; the outcome is not disputed.

What happened

- The Sikhs had spent 1763 taking the province apart in pieces.** Charat Singh Sukerchakia beat an Afghan force near Sialkot; Kasur was taken; the Jalandhar Doab fell; and the *rakhi* system was extended over districts that had been paying Lahore.
- In January 1764 the whole confederacy came together for Sirhind.**
- Zain Khan came out and was killed on the field.**
- The town was taken and destroyed for the second time in fifty-four years.**
- And then it was divided.** The territory of the Sirhind province was allocated among the misls by agreement — the beginning of the Cis-Sutlej states that will still be on the map in Part Fourteen.

THE CROSSROADS, FOR THE LAST TIME

Part Ten counted what had happened at Sirhind. Here is the list finished.

1540: Sher Shah Suri reaches Sirhind and sends the message that drives Humayun out of India. **1555:** Bairam Khan wins there and the Mughal empire is refounded. **1704:** two children are put to death by the faujdar. **1710:** Banda Singh Bahadur destroys the town. **1748:** the last Mughal victory in the Punjab is won a few miles away at Manupur. **1758:** the Marathas take it. **1761:** Abdali's allies hold it. **1762:** its troops join him at Kup. **1764:** it is taken and destroyed again.

Nine times in two hundred and twenty-four years, on one crossroads.

And after January 1764 it stops appearing, because there is nothing left to take. The province was divided among the misls and the town was never rebuilt as what it had been. **The place where the Punjab road meets the road to Delhi finally ceased to matter because the same people now held both ends of it.**

WHY THEY TOOK IT THIS TIME

- **Abdali was not there.** Between invasions, the province belonged to whoever was in it, and that was now the misls.
- **They came as one army.** A gurmata at Amritsar concentrated the whole confederacy on one objective.
- **The countryside was already theirs.** A year of *rakhi* collection had made the districts around Sirhind more theirs than the governor's.
- **And the governor came out to fight**, which was the last mistake he made.

WHY THE AFGHAN POSITION COLLAPSED

- **Garrisons without a field army.** Abdali's governors held towns in a province whose villages paid somebody else.
- **Nobody was coming.** Kabul was two months away and only came in the cold weather.
- **The revenue had gone.** A governor who cannot pay troops has a title and not much else.
- **And Panipat had removed the alternative.** The Marathas were gone; there was no third party left to play off.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

What They Did Next

The interesting part of January 1764 is not the battle. It is the meeting afterwards.

An entire Mughal province had just fallen to a confederacy of eleven autonomous divisions, none of which was subordinate to any other, all of which had been in the fighting, and all of which now wanted a share.

This book has watched exactly this moment go wrong for eleven parts. **Yashodharman's coalition dissolved on the day it won in Part Four. The Malavas and Kshudrakas could not agree on a commander in Part Two. Anandapala's confederacy in Part Five did not survive one afternoon.** Winning together and then dividing the proceeds is the point at which every alliance in this history has come apart.

The misls divided the Sirhind province among themselves, by agreement, and the division held.

It held well enough that the resulting territories — Patiala, Nabha, Jind, Kaithal, Kalsia and the rest — were still functioning states eighty years later. **They are on the map when the British arrive in Part Fourteen; some of them survived to 1947, and one of them gave its name to a district of modern Punjab.**

The mechanism was the one described in the last war. **The Sarbat Khalsa met, a gurmata was passed, and it bound everybody** — not because anybody could enforce it, but because the alternative was the thing that had destroyed every Indian coalition in these sixteen parts, and they had all read the same book about it.

Not perfectly. The misls fought each other repeatedly afterwards and the confederacy tore itself apart in the 1790s, which is how Part Twelve ends.

But in January 1764 they took a province together and split it without a war, and nothing in the previous eleven parts of this history had managed that.

The Akal Bunga, December 1764 — Thirty Men

LIKELY

The most valuable description of the Sikhs written in this century was written by a man riding with the army that came to destroy them.

WON BY

Abdali — over thirty men who would not leave a building

WHEN December 1764, during Abdali's seventh invasion.	WHERE Amritsar, at the Akal Bunga beside the tank.
WHO Bhai Gurbaksh Singh and about thirty companions, against Abdali's army.	THE EVIDENCE Qazi Nur Muhammad's <i>Jangnamah</i> — an eyewitness account by a member of the invading army.

What happened

1. **Abdali came back at the end of 1764**, for the seventh time, and found the province in Sikh hands and nobody willing to fight him for it.
2. **The misls dispersed as usual.** Fifteen years of practice; there was nothing to defend and no reason to lose men.
3. **He came to Amritsar** and found about thirty men at the Akal Bunga beside the tank, who had chosen not to go.
4. **They came out and fought and were killed**, all of them, in a short engagement against an army.
5. **And a qazi travelling with that army wrote it down.**

THE JANGNAMAH — THE MOST USEFUL BOOK IN THIS PART

Qazi Nur Muhammad accompanied Abdali's 1764–65 campaign in the train of an allied Baluch chief, and wrote a verse account of it. He was not neutral in any sense whatever. **He refers to the Sikhs throughout by a standard term of abuse and makes his religious contempt for them entirely explicit.**

And in the middle of that, describing an enemy he despises, he records a set of observations that a friendly witness could never have made credible.

He describes their **courage** in terms that go well beyond what his argument requires. He describes their **horsemanship** and the speed at which they move. He notes — and this is the passage most often quoted — that **they do not kill a fleeing enemy, and that they do not lay hands on women**, including the women of their enemies, and he states it as a rule they observe rather than an incident he witnessed.

He also, having spent the poem calling them dogs, concedes that in battle they behave like lions.

This is the second genuinely valuable outside witness in this book, after the East India Company letter of 1716 in Part Ten. And it works for the same reason: **nothing in the writer's position gave him any motive to say it.**

When a man who thinks you are vermin takes the trouble to record that you do not kill runaways or touch women, that is worth more than any amount of your own tradition.

WHY THIRTY MEN STAYED

- **The site had been destroyed twice already.** Somebody being at Amritsar when the army arrived was the point.
- **It was a choice, not a trap.** The rest of the confederacy had gone; these men elected to remain.
- **And it cost the Afghans nothing and gained them nothing**, which is the whole shape of that invasion.

WHY THE SEVENTH INVASION ACHIEVED NOTHING

- **There was no enemy to fight.** The misls dispersed and let him march about an empty province.
- **He could not stay.** Cold weather in, hot weather out, every time, for seventeen years.
- **He tried to appoint a governor and was ignored.** By this point Lahore's Sikh holders simply did not respond to offers from Kabul.
- **And his own army was finished with India.** He came twice more and neither invasion did anything at all.

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING

The Witness Who Called Them Dogs

This book has asked one question in every part for five thousand years: **who is writing, and what do they need you to believe?**

Almost every source in these eleven parts fails that test in an obvious direction. Greek writers glorifying Alexander. Harishena praising Samudragupta on a pillar. Al-Utbi counting the dead for Mahmud. Abul Fazl establishing Akbar's greatness. Sikh devotional literature edifying the community. Persian chroniclers describing Banda as a monster.

Every one of them is telling you something true, and every one of them is doing it for somebody.

The two most valuable documents in Parts Ten and Eleven are both by people who had no dog in the fight, or who had the wrong one.

In 1716, two East India Company merchants in Delhi wrote home about a procession of condemned prisoners and mentioned, because it struck them, that none of them recanted. They were negotiating customs duties. They did not care.

In 1765, a qazi riding with an Afghan army wrote a poem calling the enemy dogs on every page — and recorded that they would not strike a man who was running away and would not touch a woman.

Neither man was trying to help. The first was writing a business report. The second was writing propaganda and could not stop himself putting in what he had actually seen.

That is what evidence looks like when it is worth something. And it is why this book keeps labelling its sources instead of simply telling you what happened: **because the difference between a tradition and a fact is usually just the identity of the person who had no reason to lie.**

Lahore, 1765 — The Coin

CERTAIN

In April 1765 the Dal Khalsa took Lahore and struck money there — and the legend on it was the one Banda Singh Bahadur had used fifty-five years earlier.

WON BY The Dal Khalsa — and this time they kept it

WHEN April 1765; Abdali's last two invasions in 1766–67 change nothing.	WHERE Lahore.
WHO The Bhangi misl chiefs — Lehna Singh, Gujjar Singh and Sobha Singh — governing the city between them.	THE EVIDENCE The coins, which survive.

What happened

1. **Abdali went home in the spring of 1765** having achieved nothing in his seventh invasion.
2. **The misls took Lahore** and, this time, did not withdraw.
3. **Three chiefs divided the city between them** and governed it jointly — an arrangement that sounds unworkable and lasted about thirty years.
4. **They struck coin**, in the name of the Gurus, on the same Persian couplet Banda had used at Lohgarh in 1710.
5. **Abdali came twice more**, in 1766–67 and again afterwards. The misls dispersed, let him march about, and reoccupied everything the moment he left. **In 1767 he went back across the Indus for the last time.**
6. **He died in 1772**, of the disease of the face that had troubled him for a decade.

WHAT THE COIN SAYS, AND WHAT IT MEANS

The legend is the one from Part Ten: a Persian couplet crediting the cooking-pot, the sword, victory and ready protection to Guru Nanak and Guru Gobind Singh. **No ruler's name appears on it.**

Banda struck it at Lohgarh in 1710 and was executed six years later. **Fifty-five years afterwards, the same couplet was struck at Lahore** — the capital of the province, the seat of every governor who had hunted them, the city where Guru Arjan died in 1606 and where the execution platform at the horse market had stood for thirty years.

And it stayed. The Sikh mints at Lahore and Amritsar used versions of that legend for the rest of the century, and Ranjit Singh continued the practice: **his coinage does not carry his own name either.** He ruled from 1799 to 1839 and never put himself on his money.

That is a constitutional statement made in silver, sustained for over a hundred and thirty years, by rulers who had every incentive to do the ordinary thing.

WHY 1765 HELD WHEN 1761 DID NOT

- **Abdali was finished.** Seventeen years, nine crossings, an army in arrears and an illness that was killing him.
- **The countryside was already administered.** *Rakhi* had turned into revenue collection across most of the province; taking the city was the last step, not the first.
- **The Marathas were gone.** Panipat had removed the only other claimant.
- **And Delhi was irrelevant.** The Mughal emperor of 1765 had just signed away the revenues of Bengal to the East India Company after Buxar. Northern India had no centre at all.

WHAT HOLDING A CAPITAL COSTS

- **They became findable.** The advantage that had kept them alive for fifty years was traded away deliberately, and it could not be traded back.
- **Territory divides people.** Eleven autonomous misls with fixed districts and revenues had, for the first time, something to fight each other over.
- **The assembly lost its purpose.** The Sarbat Khalsa worked under pressure; with the pressure gone, the gurmata stopped binding.
- **And that is Part Twelve.**

THE STORY WORTH REMEMBERING — THE LAST WORD OF THIS PART

Eight Hundred and Ninety-Five Years

In April 1765, Punjabis governed the Punjab.

Stop and count backwards, because this book has been building to that sentence for eleven parts and it is worth being exact about the arithmetic.

The last time the land of the five rivers was ruled by a power based in it, and drawing its soldiers and its legitimacy from its own population, was the Hindu Shahi dynasty — and they lost Kabul in 870 and the Punjab plain within a century and a half. Part Five described their end: the last effective king murdered by his own unpaid troops in about 1021, and al-Biruni writing that of the whole house not the slightest remnant remained.

Between then and 1765: Ghaznavids from Ghazna, Ghurids from Ghor, slave sultans from Delhi, Mongol raids, Tughlaqs, Timur, Sayyids, Lodis, Mughals, Suris, Mughals again, Persians, and Afghans.

Eight hundred and ninety-five years of the Punjab being administered from somewhere else.

And the people who ended it were not a dynasty. They had no royal family, no ancient claim and no foreign patron. They were, by origin, the peasantry of the doabs, organised by an institution founded in a hill town in 1699, which had survived a bounty on every head, thirty years in the forests, two ghallugharas and the demolition of its central shrine twice in five years.

They took the capital, and they put on the coins the names of two men who had been dead for a very long time, and left their own names off.

The next thirty-four years are what they did with it, and it is not a simple story. The misls fought each other, the assembly decayed, and by the 1790s the confederacy that had beaten Ahmad Shah Abdali was tearing itself apart over districts.

And then, in 1799, a one-eyed nineteen-year-old from one of the smaller misls took Lahore.

The Whole Chapter on One Page

1748–1753	Mir Mannu governs Lahore, fighting Abdali in front and the Dal Khalsa behind. The siege of Ram Rauni is lifted through Diwan Kaura Mal; Jassa Singh Ramgarhia changes sides. Won by nobody.
1751–52	Abdali besieges Lahore for four months. Kaura Mal is killed; Mir Mannu submits and is reappointed as Kabul's governor. In April 1752 Delhi formally cedes the Punjab and Multan to Afghanistan. Won by Abdali.
Jan–Apr 1757	Abdali's fourth invasion. Delhi stripped, Mathura and Vrindavan sacked — and on the way home the Harmandir Sahib is demolished and the tank filled. Timur Shah left as viceroy. Won by Abdali.
Nov 1757	Gohalwar. Baba Deep Singh, a scholar of seventy-five, marches on Amritsar with a volunteer force and is killed a few miles short. Won by the Afghan garrison.
Mar–May 1758	The Marathas take Sirhind and then Lahore, drive out Timur Shah, and reach Attock on the Indus — the furthest north any peninsular Indian power has ever come. Adina Beg is made governor and dies in September. Won by the Marathas.
14 Jan 1761	The Third Battle of Panipat. Two months of blockade, then an attack made out of starvation. Vishwasrao shot, Bhau killed, the army destroyed. Won by Abdali — who then went home.
Feb–Mar 1761	The road home. The misls raid Abdali's returning columns and free the Panipat captives, escorting them back across northern India. Won by the Dal Khalsa.
Nov 1761	The Sikhs take Lahore and Jassa Singh Ahluwalia is proclaimed <i>Sultan-ul-Qaum</i> . They withdraw when Abdali returns.
5 Feb 1762	The Vadda Ghallughara. Abdali force-marches from Lahore and catches the Dal Khalsa escorting its families near Kup. Between ten and thirty thousand killed, most of them non-combatants. Won by Abdali.
Apr 1762	The Harmandir Sahib is blown up a second time and the tank filled again.
17 Oct 1762	Diwali at Amritsar. Eight months after Kup, the whole confederacy assembles on the same ground and fights Abdali to a standstill. He withdraws and begins offering terms. Won by nobody — which is the turning point.
1763	Sialkot, Kasur and the Jalandhar Doab fall; the <i>rakhi</i> system spreads across the province.
14 Jan 1764	Sirhind. Zain Khan killed; the town destroyed for the second time in fifty-four years; the province divided among the misls by agreement. Won by the Dal Khalsa.

Dec 1764

The Akal Bunga. Thirty men choose not to leave Amritsar and are killed — and **Qazi Nur Muhammad, riding with the invaders, writes the best outside description of the Sikhs in this century.**

Apr 1765

The Dal Khalsa takes Lahore and strikes coin there on Banda's legend, in the names of the Gurus and nobody else. **Won by the Dal Khalsa — permanently.**

1766–1767

Abdali's last invasions achieve nothing. The misls disperse, let him march, and reoccupy behind him. He recrosses the Indus for the last time in 1767 and dies in 1772. *Part Twelve begins here.*

Five patterns to carry into Part Twelve

1. **Winning every battle is not the same as holding a country.** Abdali beat Mir Mannu, destroyed the Marathas at Panipat, caught the Dal Khalsa at Kup and demolished Amritsar twice — **and went home in 1767 with nothing.** No governor he appointed survived, no revenue reached Kabul, and the province he had been formally ceded in 1752 was ruled by his enemies within thirteen years. This is the clearest case in the whole book.
2. **The institution absorbed a catastrophe and the pressure was what held it together.** Eight months from the Vadda Ghallughara to standing on the same ground at Diwali. **No other power in these eleven parts recovers from a loss on that scale — because no other power had separated its command from its commanders.** Watch what happens in Part Twelve when the pressure comes off.
3. **The single point of failure claims its seventh army.** Vishwasrao shot and Bhau gone, and the finest force in India dissolving in an hour — after Porus, Anandapala, Ghor at Tarain, Qutlugh Khwaja, Hemu and Wazir Khan. **Every army in this book that dies with its commander is a personal army. Every one that does not is an institutional one.**
4. **Territory is the trade.** Nothing to defend kept them alive for fifty years; taking Lahore in 1765 gave that up on purpose. **From here on the Sikhs can be found, besieged and negotiated with — and they can also govern.** Part Twelve is what that costs and what it buys.
5. **And the outside witnesses are the ones to trust.** Two English merchants in 1716 and a hostile qazi in 1765 — **the two most valuable sources in these two parts are both by people with no reason to say anything kind.** When you read the rest of this book, that is the standard to hold everything else to.

COMING NEXT — PART TWELVE

The Misls, 1767–1799. Twelve autonomous states with no overlord, governing the Punjab between them — and the thirty years in which the system that beat Ahmad Shah Abdali comes apart because there is nobody left to fight. Multan taken in 1772; Jammu, Kangra and the hill states brought under tribute; the Sikhs at the gates of Delhi in 1783 and the agreement they made there. Then the internal wars: Bhangi against Sukerchakia, Ramgarhia against Kanhaiya, the assembly at Amritsar meeting less and binding nobody. Mahadji Scindia's Marathas pushing back into the north; George Thomas, an Irish sailor, carving out a kingdom in Haryana; and Zaman Shah coming down from Kabul three times in the 1790s to find a province with twelve governments and no army. And at the end of it, in July 1799, **a nineteen-year-old from the smallest of the great misls walks into Lahore** — and the Punjab has one ruler for the first time in eight hundred years.

Words Used in This Part

Abdali / Durrani

Ahmad Shah, founder of the Afghan kingdom in 1747 and its ruler until 1772. He invaded India nine times.

Vahir

The non-combatant body of the community on the move — families, the old, the sick, and their possessions. Escorting it is why the Dal Khalsa could not disperse at Kup in 1762.

Ghallughara

A catastrophe or holocaust. The *Chhota* — lesser — is 1746, in Part Ten; the *Vadda* — greater — is 5 February 1762.

Rakhi

“Protection.” A fixed share of the harvest paid by a village to a misl in return for security. By 1763 it had become the revenue system of most of the Punjab.

Misl

One of the eleven — later twelve — autonomous divisions of the Dal Khalsa. Formally equal, none subordinate to another.

Sarbat Khalsa

The general assembly at Amritsar at Vaisakhi and Diwali, whose resolutions bound the whole confederacy. Two dates and a rule — the most durable institution in this book.

Gurmata

A binding resolution of the Sarbat Khalsa.

Sultan-ul-Qaum

“King of the nation” — the title by which Jassa Singh Ahluwalia was proclaimed at Lahore in November 1761.

Chauth

The Maratha revenue demand — a quarter of the assessed revenue of a territory, enforced by cavalry. The reason Maratha expansion made few friends in the north.

Zamburak

A light swivel gun carried on a camel. Part of why Abdali’s cavalry outfought the Marathas at Panipat.

Jangnamah

“Book of war.” Qazi Nur Muhammad’s verse account of Abdali’s 1764–65 campaign, written from inside the invading army — hostile throughout and invaluable.

Akal Bunga

The building beside the tank at Amritsar, later the Akal Takht, where thirty Sikhs died in December 1764.

Ram Rauni / Ramgarh

The fort at Amritsar, besieged in 1748 and afterwards rebuilt and renamed — giving the Ramgarhia misl its name.

Adina Beg Khan

Faujdar of the Jalandhar Doab, who played Mughals, Afghans, Marathas and Sikhs against one another for two decades and was briefly governor of the Punjab in 1758.

Haah da naara

“The cry of protest” — the objection made by the Nawab of Malerkotla at Sirhind in 1704, and the reason Sikh armies afterwards spared his state.

Cis-Sutlej states

The territories south and east of the Sutlej divided among the misls after Sirhind in 1764 — Patiala, Nabha, Jind and the rest, still on the map when the British arrive.

Sources used for this part

- **Qazi Nur Muhammad**, *Jangnamah* (1765) — an eyewitness account of Abdali’s seventh invasion by a member of his army, in Ganda Singh’s edition
- Persian histories of the later Mughal period, including the *Siyar-ul-Mutakherin* of Ghulam Husain Khan
- Afghan accounts of Ahmad Shah Abdali’s campaigns
- Maratha correspondence and the Peshwa daftar records for the 1758 campaign and for Panipat — an unusually rich body of contemporary letters
- Sikh sources of the later eighteenth and nineteenth centuries — *Prachin Panth Prakash* and related works — for the Ghallugharas, Gohalwar and the internal organisation, treated as tradition and labelled as such
- **The coins of the Sikh mints at Lahore and Amritsar**, which carry the legend used by Banda Singh Bahadur in 1710
- Ganda Singh’s documentary work on Ahmad Shah Durrani and on the eighteenth-century Punjab; Hari Ram Gupta’s history of the Sikhs
- Standard modern accounts of the Third Battle of Panipat, the Maratha northern expansion, and the Afghan invasions

A NOTE ON DISAGREEMENT

The open questions here include: the casualty figures at Panipat and at the Vadda Ghallughara, both of which vary by a factor of three between sources; the number of captives freed on the road in 1761; whether coin was struck at Lahore in 1761 as well as in 1765; whether a Sikh alliance would have changed the outcome at Panipat, which is unanswerable and endlessly asserted; and the origin of Abdali’s fatal illness.

Three things about method.

First, **the two desecrations of the Harmandir Sahib are stated as documented acts of policy** and are explained in military terms — a fixed target substituting for an army that could not be caught. That explanation is not a justification and is not offered as one.

Second, **this part has again named individuals rather than communities**. Diwan Kaura Mal, a Hindu Khatri, saved the Sikhs at Ram Rauni and died fighting Afghans for a Mughal governor. Adina Beg Khan changed sides four times in twenty years. The Nawab of Malerkotla’s protest in 1704 protected his state for two centuries while his successors’ troops fought at Kup. **None of these people can be explained by their religion, and the record does not support trying.**

Third, **the most important source in this part is hostile**. Qazi Nur Muhammad despised the people he was describing and said so on every page, and what he recorded about their conduct in war is worth more than any friendly account precisely because of it. Where this book has used him, it has said who he was.